

Dear Editors and Reviewers:

We would like to confirm that, compared with our BIBM 2017 proceeding paper, this extended journal version has at least 75% new contents.

All sections were significantly extended, detailed as follows.

[Background]

We added 15 papers into the background literature and gave a thorough discussion on our research background as well as related work.

[Methods]

We described all three steps in our methods with significantly greater details.

[Results and Discussion]

We added greater details of results obtained from our methods, including detailed explanation and discussion in text, seven new figures, and two new tables.

[Conclusions]

We enriched this section by adding discussion on alternative methods, namely, UpSetR and Fisher's method, to analyze intersecting differentially expressed miRNAs (DEMs).

Best,

Jingshan Huang on behalf of all authors